

Argument Audit — Chapters 3+

Test applied to everything: does it carry weight on the load-bearing thread, or is it survey/insurance? The thread:

object taken in → first a distinct experience → must be described to enter language → must be named to refer in absence → we learn counterfactual talk → counterfactuals require keeping track of *which* individual → Kripke's rigidity is the method of holding the individual fixed across counterfactuals → **local rigidity** (direct experience makes any counterfactual I build mandatorily about *this* object) is the foundation → name rigidity is built on first-hand experienced rigidity → so local rigidity is the cognitive foundation of name rigidity → x^o/x^c just makes this expressible.

One foil per move. Everything else is freight unless it blocks an objection that would actually stop the thread.

The structural diagnosis

The draft has **three foils where it needs one**, and the redundancy is most of the bloat:

- **Russell** — the foil that earns its place. He found the mechanism (direct, non-descriptive reference) and restricted it (acquaintance/infallibility). Your whole move is *un-restricting* it. This is the only historical figure the thread *needs*.
- **Evans / Recanati / Devitt** — the "existing cognitive implementations." These exist to show "others tried and stayed representationalist." That's *one sentence* of work, currently spread over §4.7-4.7.4 plus a deep Recanati contrast in §5.1.
- **The indexicalist tradition** (Pelczar, Rami, Künne, Textor, Tarnowski, García-Carpintero) in §5.3 — exists to show "names-as-demonstratives has been proposed before, but as *semantics*, not *metasemantics*." Also one sentence of work, currently a paragraph plus six references.

The Sellars/Brandom contrast (§5.2) is a *fourth* foil, for the R operator specifically. It's the most cuttable of all because the unification claim it supports ("same R, different argument types") is, as your reviewer noted, currently notational rather than substantive.

Recommendation in one line: keep Russell as the spine foil. Demote Evans/Recanati/Devitt to a single paragraph. Demote the indexicalists to a single paragraph. Cut the Sellars/Brandom contrast entirely. This removes ~15 references and three sub-branches without touching a single step of your thread.

Chapter 3 (printed §4) — From Russell to Kripke

This chapter is mostly load-bearing and should survive largely intact. It does real work: it

establishes that descriptions can't supply rigidity (your "must be named" step needs this) and that Russell found-then-restricted the mechanism (your "un-restrict it" move depends on this).

KEEP (does real work):

- §4.2 the three Kripkean arguments — but **compress**. You need rigidity-of-names *granted* so you can ask the cognitive question. You do not need all three arguments in full. Keep the modal argument (Aristotle counterfactual) because it is your "keeping track across counterfactuals" step in Kripke's own voice. Reduce epistemic (Gödel/Schmidt) and semantic (substitutivity) to two sentences each, or a single sentence noting they converge. Right now they read like a textbook recap.
- §4.3 why descriptions can't supply rigidity — **keep, this is a thread step**. The scope problem and that both earn their place: they show rigidity is *imposed from outside* a description, never intrinsic. This directly supports "we must *name*, description won't do."
- §4.4 Russell's mechanism and retreat — **the core of the chapter, keep all of it**. The directness/infallibility prising-apart is your pivot. This is the best paragraph in the draft for your purposes.
- §4.5 baptism and causal chain — **keep, compressed**. You need Kripke's positive picture on the table so you can say "he describes the practice, not the cognitive operation." But the two Kripke quotes ("better picture," "necessary and sufficient conditions") appear *again* here after §3.3 — quote once, total, in the whole thesis.

CUT or DEMOTE (freight):

- §4.7.1 Evans, §4.7.2 Recanati, §4.7.3 Devitt, §4.7.4 shared architecture — **collapse all four into one paragraph**. The entire work these do is: "Three serious attempts to fill Kripke's cognitive gap — Evans's discriminating conception, Recanati's mental files, Devitt's causal-descriptivism — share a representationalist template: an internal item (conception/file/complex) related to an external referent. Each presupposes rather than explains the prior capacity to single out a particular. That capacity is what I will call local rigidity." That's it. You lose nothing the thread needs. The per-author detail (Evans's propositionalism, Recanati's file typology, Devitt's reference-shift handling) is journal-article granularity that the thread doesn't use.
- **References this lets you drop from the body**: the detailed Recanati file-typology citations (Mental Files chs. 3–4, 7), the Goodman 2016 critique (n.14), the Hansen & Rey *Disputatio* critique (n.12), McCullagh 2005 (n.3, n.17). None of these advance your thread; they're scholarly insurance against "did you know about X."

Net for Ch.3: trim the three Kripkean arguments to one-plus-gestures, quote Kripke once, and compress four sub-sections to one paragraph. The chapter's real spine — descriptions fail, Russell found-and-restricted the mechanism — stays.

Chapter 4 (printed §5) — The Functional-Mode Distinction

This is where the bloat is worst, because it's where the surveying instinct peaks. The chapter's *job* on your thread is small and clean: **introduce x^o/x^c , show local rigidity is what x^o -coordination has constitutively, re-read de re/de dicto and the necessary a posteriori as level-distinctions.** That's four moves. The chapter currently spends as much space situating itself against Recanati, Sellars, Brandom, and six indexicalists as it does making those four moves.

KEEP (does real work):

- §5.1 the x^o/x^c distinction itself, *the bird examples* — **keep, this is the formalism your thread says "just makes it easier to explain."** The "that bird is injured" / "birds fly" contrast and the child-who-can-point vs child-who-can-define test are exactly the right level of concreteness. This is your best exposition.
- §5.1 the " x^o is still language, not perception" claim — **keep, but this needs to become an argument, not a denial** (your reviewer flagged this; on your thread it matters because "first a distinct experience $\rightarrow$ must be described to enter language" is precisely the experience/language boundary x^o straddles). This is the one place I'd *add* rather than cut.
- §5.3 local rigidity proper — **the heart of the chapter, keep all of it.** "That bird could have been larger," the bird held fixed across modal variation by present perceptual contact — this is your thread's pivot sentence ("whatever counterfactual I build, it's mandatorily about the object I'm experiencing") in full dress. The preserved-link-vs-built-in-property framing is also load-bearing and original. Keep.
- §5.4 de re/de dicto as x^o/x^c — **keep, compressed.** This is a genuine thread step (your "we learn counterfactual talk" cashes out as: the same level-distinction explains the de re/de dicto ambiguity). But cut the medieval-origins gesture and the Wiggins/Fine footnote (n.26) — they're "see also," not argument.
- §5.5 necessary a posteriori as level-distinction — **keep, compressed.** Hesperus/Phosphorus and water/H₂O both, but you don't need *both* fully worked; do Hesperus/Phosphorus in full and water/H₂O in three sentences. Cut the Salmon/Chalmers/Soames footnote (n.30) and the Putnam-natural-kinds footnote (n.29) down to a single "I take no stand on the metaphysics of natural kinds" line.

CUT (freight — this is the big one):

- §5.1 the **entire three-part Recanati contrast** (unit of analysis / topology of interface / treatment of common nouns) — **cut to one paragraph.** The work it does on your thread: "The nearest existing view is Recanati's mental files; mine differs in locating the distinction at the level of public word-modes rather than private mental vehicles, and in applying symmetrically to common nouns and names." Two sentences. The three-fold itemized contrast, the vehicle/content framing, the ER-relation typology, the "actualist commitment" — all journal-article apparatus. The symmetry-to-common-nouns point is

worth keeping (one sentence) because your thread starts with "that bird," not "Aristotle."

- §5.2 **R as Coordination, the entire Sellars/Brandom contrast — cut the contrast, keep a stripped definition of R.** Your thread uses R as "the coordination between word and what it's about." That's all the downstream argument needs. The claim that R *unifies* Sellars's entry/inference transitions is a separate thesis about inferentialism that you neither need nor (per your reviewer) currently establish as more than notational. Cutting this removes Sellars (n.16), Brandom (n.17), McCullagh again, and the whole "is this notational or substantive" vulnerability. Keep maybe four sentences: R coordinates two items; the items can be word-and-experience ($R(\text{bird}^o, E\{\text{BIRD}\})$) or word-and-word ($R(\text{bird}^c, \text{fly}^c)$); it's a relation sustained by practice, not a function the speaker computes. Done.
- §5.3 the **indexicalist tradition survey** (Russell late view, Recanati *Direct Reference*, Pelczar & Rainsbury, Rami, Künné, Textor, Tarnowski, García-Carpintero) plus the three "points of departure" — **cut to one paragraph.** Work it does: "Names have been treated as indexicals/demonstratives before (Recanati, and others). Those are claims about names' *semantic category*; mine is a claim about the *cognitive coordination* any such semantics presupposes. So I don't compete with them — I sit underneath them." Three sentences. The six-reference survey and the nambiguity discussion (n.22) go. Your thread never uses nambiguity.

ADD (the one place):

- A real defense of x^o -as-language-not-perception in §5.1 (see Whole-thesis point below). This is the only addition I'd recommend, and it pays for itself by being the claim everything downstream leans on.

Net for Ch.4: the chapter loses its three foils (Recanati-deep, Sellars/Brandom, indexicalists) and roughly a dozen references, keeps all four of its actual argument moves, and gains one paragraph of real defense where it's currently weakest. This is the single highest-leverage cut in the thesis.

Chapter 5 (printed §6) — The PRU Account

This chapter is the most thread-faithful in the draft and needs the *least* surgery. It walks your flow's back half almost exactly: x^o -coordination → problem of absence → baptism as lifting → transmission → attribution-after-transmission. Keep the spine; trim the framework-exposition and one over-built formalism.

KEEP (does real work — most of the chapter):

- §6.2 local rigidity as x^o , the language primitive — keep.
- §6.3 the problem of absence — **keep, this is your "must name it to refer in absence" step, stated perfectly.** "A name is a device for exporting x^o -rigidity into the space of

absence... names as portable demonstratives." This is your thread's title, *From Local to Portable Rigidity*, earning itself.

- §6.4 baptism as lifting — **keep, the constructive core**. $R(h^o, N^c)$. "Not transferred, not duplicated: lifted." This is the payoff of the whole thesis.
- §6.6 attribution after transmission, the $R(D_i, N^c)$ conjunction — **keep, this is what makes you not-a-descriptivist**, and it's original. The revisable-conjunction device answers the objection that would otherwise kill the thread.

CUT or COMPRESS (freight):

- §6.1 the PRU framework exposition — **compress**. You already say (§2.5) the framework is defended elsewhere. Then introduce only the three primitives the chapter *uses* ($\{X\}$, $\langle x \rangle$, R , and the x^o/x^c modes) in a tight half-page and point to the preprint. The attractor/basin/dynamical-systems ontology ("unified attractor state," "falling into the $\{X\}$ -basin") is doing no work in *this* chapter's argument and creates the practice-vs-mechanism tension your reviewer flagged. Either cut the dynamical-systems language here or add one sentence saying the practice (Ch.4 §5.2) is what the mechanism implements. Cutting is cleaner for a thesis that doesn't defend PRU.
- §6.5 causal chains as testimonial networks — **keep the core, trim the three-channel taxonomy**. Your thread needs "the name keeps doing its tracking work across generations because the community sustains the practice." It does *not* need the $\langle N \rangle / \tau(N) / \sigma(N)$ three-way apparatus fully built. The surrogate-objects σ branch is the most cuttable: you concede a blind historian refers fine without it (so σ isn't load-bearing), which means σ is enrichment, not mechanism. Mention surrogates in a clause; don't give them a formal symbol and a sub-argument.
- §6.6 the Hesperus/Phosphorus formalism — **fix and simplify** (it's currently broken — a formula ends on "or" with content cut). Once fixed, it's good and stays. But you don't need *both* the §5.5 necessary-a-posteriori treatment *and* a second full formal re-derivation here. Cross-reference §5.5 and keep here only the new content: that the *attributions* are what's revised, the *anchor* is what's shared.

Net for Ch.5: trim the framework front-matter, drop the σ formalism to a clause, deduplicate the Hesperus/Phosphorus treatment. The constructive spine — absence, lifting, attribution — is untouched.

Whole-thesis recommendations

1. The single structural fix that recovers your thread: cut from four foils to one. Russell is the only historical interlocutor your argument *needs* (find-and-restrict $\rightarrow$ un-restrict). Evans/Recanati/Devitt collapse to one paragraph ("others tried, stayed representationalist"). The indexicalists collapse to one paragraph ("others said names-are-demonstratives, but as semantics, not metasemantics"). Sellars/Brandom go entirely. This alone removes ~15

references and three argument-branches and makes the spine visible. Nothing in your ten-step flow loses support.

2. Reference count is the symptom, foil count is the disease. Don't hunt references one by one — cut the *branches*, and the references they carry leave with them. After the cuts above, the working bibliography is roughly: Kripke (NN, I&N), Russell (PLA, On Denoting), Wittgenstein (Tractatus, PI), Kaplan (Demonstratives, for dthat), Quine (Reference and Modality, for de re/de dicto), LaPorte (SEP, for the gap), Recanati (Mental Files, as the one named representationalist foil), and your own PRU preprint. That's the set that does work. Everything else is "see also."

3. The one thing to *add*, not cut. The x^o -is-language-not-perception claim (§5.1) is the keystone of your thread — it's the hinge between "first a distinct experience" and "must be described to enter language." Right now it's asserted. Spend the space you save by cutting the indexicalist survey on actually arguing it: x^o is language because it's a *word-use*, governed by the public word-form and correctable by the community, even though it requires coordination with what's encountered. It is not perception because perception ($E\{X\}$) can occur without the word, and the word can be misapplied to the wrong instance. That contrast — word can misfire on experience, experience can occur wordlessly — is what makes x^o a third thing rather than either pole. One good paragraph here is worth more than all six indexicalist citations.

4. After cutting, re-test the thread end to end. Read only the kept material in your flow's order. If each step still follows from the one before with the surviving foil/example, the cut was clean. If a step now floats (no support), that's a reference that was doing work — put it back. My prediction: nothing floats. The kept Russell, the kept bird examples, the kept baptism formalism carry every step.

What I am *not* recommending: touching the thread itself, rewriting Ch.1-2 (the Introduction already states your flow well and the three-level "object" reading is genuinely yours and load-bearing), or adding new argument. This is subtraction plus one paragraph, not a rewrite.